

GARGANO — THE FORGOTTEN COAST

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CAP. 1 — INTRO: THE TRABUCCO

Sit down for a moment on the edge.

Look down. Water's right below your feet. Juniper beams holding everything together — same wood my great-grandfather used when he built this structure. Ninety years of salt, wind, and waves. Still holding.

My name is Ferdinando. Sixty-eight years old. Fourth generation on this trabucco. My great-grandfather built it in the thirties, my grandfather fished here his whole life, my father too. I started at eleven — up at four in the morning, dropping the nets, hauling up whatever came.

Thirty years ago I opened the restaurant on the trabucco. Not because I'd stopped fishing — because the fish I was catching was so good it was worth cooking it right here, on the spot, with the sea underneath.

I'm going to tell you about this coast the way someone who's spent their whole life here knows it. From the trabucco you can see everything. And you understand everything.

CAP. 2 — THE TRABUCCHI: FISHING MACHINES ON THE SEA

A trabucco is not a shack on the water.

It's a machine.

A fishing machine built on rock, engineered with a precision that still surprises today. The antennae — those long beams that fan out over the sea — hold the net. The net drops vertically into the water through a system of ropes and counterweights. When the fish pass underneath, you pull it up.

The power is human — no engines, no electricity. A system of levers and pulleys that my great-grandfather knew by heart and that I learned from my father by watching, not reading.

The trabucchi on the Gargano are something specific — you won't find them like this anywhere else in the world. You'll find them in Abruzzo and Molise too, but the ones on the Gargano are the oldest, the biggest, the best built.

The coast between Vieste and Peschici once had fifty of them. Today about twenty remain, almost all turned into restaurants. The fishing still happens — but what ends up on your plate in the evening came up in that net that very morning. Doesn't seem like a bad deal to me.

CAP. 3 — LESINA: THE LAKE BETWEEN THE SEA AND THE LAND

Lake Lesina is the first surprise of northern Gargano.

You drive along the main road and see the sea on your right. Then suddenly, on your left, a lake. Forty-two square kilometres of still water, separated from the Adriatic by a strip of sand just a few hundred metres wide.

The water is brackish — neither sea nor fresh water. Seawater comes in through two man-made channels, fresh water flows in from the streams. The result is a unique environment — eels, sea bass, sea bream growing in conditions completely different from the open sea.

The oysters of Lesina. I've heard about them my whole life. The lake temperatures are perfect — not too warm, not too cold. The oysters grow slowly, feeding on the lake's plankton, and develop a flavour unlike any sea oyster. Sweeter, less iodine, with something mineral I can't quite put into words.

The village of Lesina sits on the northern edge of the lake. Three thousand people, a small but living historic centre, the church of Santa Maria Assunta looking out over the water. Mass tourism doesn't reach here — it's a place for people looking for something real.

CAP. 4 — RODI GARGANICO: CITRUS GROVES BY THE SEA

Rodi Garganico has the best smell on the Gargano.

In winter, when you drive toward the village, you smell the citrus before you see it. Oranges, tangerines, lemons — grown on terraced hillsides sloping down to the sea for centuries.

The position is something else. Rodi sits on a headland facing west over the Gulf of Manfredonia. The sunset here is something you don't forget — the sun drops into the water right in front of you, the Diomedean Islands on the horizon — the ancient name of the Tremiti, what the Greeks used to call them.

The historic centre is medieval — narrow streets, low arches, steps leading down to the harbour. The harbour is still a fishermen's harbour — the boats go out at night and come back in the morning. Same scene as fifty years ago.

The fish from Rodi is famous across the Gargano. Not for any particular reason — just the fact that Rodi's fishermen really do go out every night, in any weather, and bring back whatever they find. It's not folklore. It's work.

CAP. 5 — PESCHICI: THE VILLAGE THAT WON'T FALL

Peschici looks like it's been about to fall into the sea for a thousand years.

And it never does.

The historic centre clings to a rocky spur on the edge of the northern headland. The white houses are stacked on top of each other, connected by outdoor staircases, arches spanning across the alleys, terraces that open onto nothing but air.

The Norman castle at the top — 10th century, still standing, towers still intact. Built by the Normans to defend the coast from Saracen raids. A thousand years later it's still there, and the view from up top takes in the whole coast all the way to Vieste.

In summer Peschici explodes. Three thousand people become fifty thousand. The alleys fill with German, Dutch, Italian tourists. Restaurants have queues outside. Every terrace is a table.

In winter Peschici is a different place. Old men playing cards at the bar, fishermen mending nets at the harbour, children playing on the steps. A real village. Not a stage set.

CAP. 6 — THE ROAD: RODI TO PESCHICI

There's a road you won't forget.

The provincial road from Rodi Garganico to Peschici. It's not a motorway. It's not easy going. In places it's narrow, with blind corners and a drop on the right-hand side. But what you see from that road you won't see anywhere else.

At a certain point the road climbs. The headland rises above the sea. And suddenly, beyond the crash barrier, you've got a hundred metres of white rock below you and then

the sea. Green, flat, with coves cut into the rock like gashes. The Diomedean Islands on the horizon. On clear days, it feels like you're suspended in mid-air.

Along the road there are places to pull over — lay-bys at the edge, the odd natural widening. People stop, get out of the car, take photos. I get it. I still stop myself, after forty years of driving it.

But let me tell you something.

That road is narrow. The bends come fast. If you stop, pull completely off the road — not halfway in and halfway out. In summer you've got campervans, coaches, motorbikes coming through. Pulling back out can be dangerous if you're not paying attention. The view is worth stopping for. Just stop properly.

I always say go early in the morning, before the traffic builds up. The morning light on that coast is different from any other time of day. The sea is almost white. The shadows are long. And you're alone.

CAP. 7 — THE SEA: WHERE TO SWIM

The problem with northern Gargano is that the best sea isn't visible from the road.

There are no wide beaches. What you've got are coves — gaps in the white rock, reachable on foot or by boat, with water so clear in places it barely seems to be there.

From Peschici, along the coast toward Vieste, there are coves you can reach on foot by following marked paths down. They're not easy walks — descents over rock, sometimes with steps cut in, sometimes without. But at the bottom you'll find water with no colour because it's too clear to have one.

The alternative is renting a rubber dinghy. From the harbour at Peschici or Rodi you can rent one without a licence. Two hours on the water, you pick where to stop. It's the best way to see this coast. From the sea you understand how it's shaped. From land you only see the road.

One important thing: the most beautiful coves are the ones with no name. You won't find them on Google Maps. You find them by asking a local — the boat rental guy, the barman at the harbour, the fisherman mending his nets. Ask them: where do you go for a swim? That's the place.

CAP. 8 — THE ORIGINS: WHY THE TRABUCCHI EXIST

My great-grandfather didn't build the trabucco because he was romantic.

He built it because he was hungry.

This coast is rocky. There are no beaches where you can drag a boat ashore and go out with ordinary nets. The seabed drops off quickly, the currents are unpredictable, the sea can kick up in half an hour. Fishing from the open sea here meant risking your life every single time.

The trabucco is the answer to that problem. You build on rock, which is stable. You lower the net from above, without going out to sea. You wait for the fish to pass. And when they do, you pull up.

The idea isn't from the Gargano. It comes from the Middle East — similar machines existed in Syria and Lebanon as far back as the Middle Ages. It arrived in Italy through Mediterranean trade routes. On the Gargano it took hold because this coastline seemed made for these structures.

The word "trabucco" comes from the old French "trabuc" — a medieval war machine that hurled rocks. The similarity is in the mechanism: counterweights, levers, calibrated force. Except instead of throwing stones, it drops nets.

My great-grandfather knew nothing of any of this. He knew it worked. And that it fed his family. That's enough.

CAP. 9 — THE COAST: BETWEEN TRABUCCHI AND COVES

The coast between Peschici and Vieste is the most beautiful stretch of northern Gargano.

No wide beaches. Just coves of white rock, small, reachable on foot down steep paths or by boat hugging the shore.

Along the coast, the family trabucchi are still there. The ones that haven't become restaurants are still in use — sons, grandchildren, still fishing the old way. Not out of necessity. So as not to forget how it's done.

My trabucco is between Peschici and Vieste. In the early morning, when the sun is still low, the water beneath the beams is green and transparent. You can see the bottom. You can see the fish going past. Then you drop the net and wait.

My son doesn't want to fish. He's studying engineering in Bologna. I understand. But I hope that when he comes back, sometimes, he'll come out here with me in the morning. To keep the thread alive.

CAP. 10 — THE FOOD: FROM THE TRABUCCO TO THE PLATE

What I cook on the trabucco doesn't follow a fixed menu.

It depends on what I've caught. It depends on the sea. It depends on the season.

If that morning mackerel came up, we eat mackerel. If cuttlefish came up, we eat cuttlefish. If nothing much came, we go with what the fisherman brought in the day before. But it's rare that nothing comes.

The dish I make best is brodetto alla garganica. Mixed fish — scorpionfish, weever, gurnard, whatever's there — with tomato, garlic, chilli, and a drizzle of good oil at the end. You eat it with toasted bread dunked in the broth. No fork. Hands.

The Lesina oysters I serve raw. Just lemon. Anyone who puts sauce on them has missed the point entirely. A Lesina oyster already has everything it needs.

The wine is Falanghina del Gargano — white, fresh, with citrus on the nose. Made here, two kilometres away. Doesn't need to travel.

CAP. 11 — THE SEASONS: NORTHERN GARGANO OUTSIDE AUGUST

Let me tell you something most tourists don't know.

Northern Gargano outside August is paradise.

May: the citrus groves of Rodi are still loaded. The sea is cool but not cold. The trabucchi are open but not packed. Prices are normal.

June: the sea warms up. The coves are half-empty. You can get a table at a restaurant without booking three weeks in advance.

September: the sea is at its best. The tourists have gone. The restaurant kitchens work at their own pace. You sleep.

October: almost deserted. The light is low and golden. The nearby forest starts to change colour. The sea is still warm enough for a swim. And there's no one around.

August I leave to the Germans. I respect them — they come every year, bring the kids, they genuinely love this place. But August isn't the real Gargano. It's the summer version of the Gargano. Beautiful, but not the one I prefer.

CAP. 12 — WHAT TO DO: FERDINANDO'S TIPS

First thing: find a trabucco that does dinner and book a table for the evening. Not lunch — dinner. When the sun goes down over the sea and the light turns orange and you're eating fresh fish on wooden beams with the water under your feet — that's something you won't forget.

Second thing: go to Lesina. Not just the lake. Go into the village. Find someone who'll let you try the fresh oysters. If you find them raw with lemon right there on the spot, eat

them.

Third thing: get a boat. Even just for two hours. The coast seen from the water is completely different. The coves you can't reach from land, the trabucchi seen from the sea, the sea caves. Worth every euro.

Fourth thing: get up early. Northern Gargano in the early morning, before eight, is a different thing altogether. The sea is flat, the light is low, there's no one around. It's what I see every morning for sixty years. Worth the six o'clock alarm.

CAP. 13 — THE EELS OF LESINA: FOOD FROM THE LAKE

I already talked about Lake Lesina. But I left out the most important thing.

The eels.

Lake Lesina has been famous for eels for centuries. Brackish water, rich in nutrients, mild temperatures all year round — perfect conditions for this fish that migrates, lives for decades, doesn't give itself up easily.

Lesina eel comes a few different ways. Grilled — over a wood fire, with salt and lemon, nothing else. In a brodetto — with tomato, onion, chilli. Fried. Marinated. The old-timers from the lake cooked it every way you can think of, and none of them were wrong.

My father ate it every Friday. He said eel gives you strength for the whole week. Maybe he was exaggerating. But he was ninety-two when he died and never stopped working on the trabucco. The eel must have done something.

CAP. 14 — THE TURKS ON THE COAST: THE WATCHTOWERS

Along this coast there are towers.

Watchtowers, built in the 16th and 17th centuries by the Spanish who ruled the Kingdom of Naples. One every few kilometres — so that from the walkway of one you could see the next. A chain of stone sentinels.

The reason was simple: Ottoman raids. Turkish fleets regularly swept the coasts of the southern Mediterranean. The towers were there to spot incoming ships — a signal fire, an alarm, enough time to hide or run.

The towers are still there. Some restored, some in ruins. When I'm working on the trabucco and look up at the coast, I can always spot two or three of them — dark silhouettes against the green. Centuries later, still watching the sea.

CAP. 15 — THE WIND: HOW IT CHANGES THE GARGANO

Northern Gargano is never quite the same twice.

The tramontane — the north wind — changes everything.

When the tramontane blows, the sea rises within hours. The waves push into the coves. The colour of the water shifts from turquoise to dark green. Foam settles on the rocks like snow.

With the tramontane you don't fish. You don't go out in a boat. You don't lower the trabucco net — the movement of the water would tear it. You wait. You shelter. You drink coffee and watch the sea from a distance.

I learned to read the sky before I learned to read words. My father would say: look there, that cloud to the northwest. Watch how it moves. You don't need the weather forecast. You just need to look.

CAP. 16 — THE SCENTS: THE GARGANO YOU CAN'T SEE

You can recognise northern Gargano with your eyes closed.

In summer: pine resin, salt air, wild scrub flowers. Early in the morning, before the heat flattens everything, the air has a smell you won't find anywhere else.

In spring: the citrus groves of Rodi and Vico del Gargano in bloom. Orange blossom has a powerful scent, almost sweet, that reaches you from the sea. If you come in April or May, roll down your windows as soon as you enter the citrus area. You won't regret it.

In autumn: wet wood, mushrooms, earth after rain. The forest breathing.

I work on the trabucco and always feel the wind. Not all winds are the same. The wind from land brings pine. The wind from the sea brings salt. The wind from the north brings cold and rain. Every wind has its own smell. After so many years, I can tell the weather before I even look at the sky.

CAP. 17 — THE HARD PARTS: LIVING WELL OUT HERE

People ask me: living here — doesn't it weigh on you?

It does and it doesn't.

It does in winter — when the road is closed for snow, when the nearest hospital is a long drive, when you want to buy something and the shop is shut. Life in the inland areas of Puglia is not easy. Services are lacking, job opportunities are thin, young people leave. It's a real problem.

But it doesn't weigh on you when you're on the trabucco at six in the morning and the sea is flat and the light is low. It doesn't weigh on you when you know everyone in the village and no one is a stranger. It doesn't weigh on you when you know that what you're eating you caught yourself, or someone you know grew it.

It's a difficult balance. I don't know if it works for everyone. I know it works for me. And that I've never left.

CAP. 18 — CLOSING: FERDINANDO SAYS GOODBYE

My great-grandfather built this trabucco with his own hands.

The juniper beams he cut from the forest above Peschici. He brought them down by mule. It took him a year. Then he fished here for thirty years. Then my grandfather. Then my father. Then me.

Four generations. Same wood. Same water. Same fish.

When the guests sit here in the evening and watch the sunset and eat what I caught that morning, I think my great-grandfather would have understood. Maybe not the restaurant part. But he'd have understood the idea — this place is beautiful, the fish is good, people should come and see it.

This coast doesn't need to be invented. It just needs to be looked at.

Enjoy your time on the Gargano. And if you pass a trabucco, stop. It's worth it.

This promontory has other faces.

The coves of Vieste seen from the water, the grotto where the archangel left the mark of his cloak, the islands of Lucio Dalla on the horizon, the hilltop villages above the lake. Each one has someone to tell its story. Someone who never left.

The Gargano doesn't end here.